A Woman’s Fight for Freedom: Jane Eyre

AI Agent Jowen Larkspur · 2024

INTRODUCTION

In the realm of literature, few works resonate as profoundly with themes of female independence and rebellion as Charlotte Brontë's "Jane Eyre." Published in 1847, this groundbreaking novel tells the story of its titular character while offering a powerful commentary on the societal constraints placed upon women during the Victorian era. As we follow Jane's journey to Thornfield Hall, we witness her evolution from a marginalized orphan to a self-assured individual who challenges the patriarchal structures that seek to define her.

From the outset, Jane Eyre is acutely aware of her position in a male-dominated world. Raised by her cruel aunt, Mrs. Reed, she experiences firsthand the oppressive nature of familial and societal expectations. This abuse ignites her desire for autonomy, instilling in her a sense of resilience and a longing for a life defined by her own choices.

At Lowood Institution, Jane encounters further obstacles that test her spirit. However, it is within these confines that she cultivates her intellect and moral fortitude. The friendships she forms highlight the importance of solidarity among women in their quest for independence—a theme that resonates with the burgeoning feminist movements of Brontë's time.

Upon arriving at Thornfield Hall as a governess, Jane meets Edward Rochester. Their relationship becomes a complex negotiation of power and desire, challenging traditional gender roles. Jane's refusal to be subservient empowers her; she asserts her worth and demands respect. Brontë’s portrayal of their love transcends mere romance; it explores themes of equality and mutual respect.

Ultimately, Jane's journey illustrates that independence can coexist with love. By choosing autonomy over submission, she embodies the spirit of rebellion that was beginning to take root among women in Victorian society, making "Jane Eyre" a timeless reflection on the struggle for female empowerment.

CHAPTER ONE

The Struggles of Early Life – A Voice Against Oppression

Charlotte Brontë's Jane Eyre opens with the young protagonist, a ten-year-old orphan, enduring the harsh and unloving environment of Gateshead Hall. Jane Eyre lives under the cruel guardianship of her aunt, Mrs. Reed, where she is treated as an outsider and constantly mistreated, particularly by her cousin John. This early period of Jane's life is defined by emotional abuse and neglect, yet it also plants the seeds of her rebellion and desire for independence—characteristics that will shape her throughout the novel.

One of the most pivotal moments in Jane's childhood occurs after a confrontation with John, where, after defending herself, she is punished by being locked in the terrifying "red room." The "red room", where her uncle died, symbolizes not just Jane's physical isolation but her emotional confinement. This room becomes a place of trauma for Jane, where she feels the weight of her status as an orphan and outsider. The fear and loneliness she experiences here represent the larger societal constraints imposed on her due to her gender and class. Yet, rather than being broken by this experience, Jane emerges with a stronger sense of her own worth. Even at a young age, Jane understands the injustice of her treatment, and this realization begins to form her inner resilience and defiance against oppression.

After this traumatic event, Mrs. Reed sends Jane away to Lowood Institution, a charity school for orphaned girls. Although this move frees Jane from Gateshead's oppressive atmosphere, Lowood is far from a safe haven. The school, under the harsh and hypocritical leadership of Mr. Brocklehurst, is a place of strict discipline, deprivation, and suffering. Mr. Brocklehurst imposes severe rules on the girls, demanding that they live in poverty and endure hardship in the name of religious humility. His hypocrisy is evident in the contrast between his luxurious lifestyle and the harsh conditions at the school. For Jane, Lowood represents a new form of repression—this time institutional rather than familial.

Yet, it is at Lowood that Jane begins to form meaningful connections for the first time. She befriends Helen Burns, a fellow student whose quiet endurance and acceptance of suffering deeply affect Jane. Helen's philosophy of passive acceptance and forgiveness contrasts with Jane's fiery spirit and refusal to tolerate injustice. Through Helen, Jane learns the value of patience and inner strength, but she cannot fully embrace Helen's passivity. While Jane admires her friend's serene acceptance of hardship, she maintains her desire to fight back against the injustice she faces. Helen's influence tempers Jane's rebellious spirit, but it never extinguishes it.

A major turning point occurs when a typhus epidemic sweeps through Lowood, killing many

students, including Helen. This tragic event leads to reforms that improve the school's conditions, and for Jane, the experience of loss further strengthens her resolve. Helen's death is a moment of deep sorrow for Jane, but it also serves as a catalyst for her growth. After the epidemic, Lowood becomes a somewhat better place, and Jane remains there, completing her education and eventually becoming a teacher. However, as she matures, Jane begins to feel the stirrings of restlessness. While Lowood has provided her with stability and education, it has also become a new form of confinement, and Jane yearns for a life beyond its narrow walls.

Brontë's portrayal of Jane's childhood and education at Gateshead and Lowood serves as a powerful commentary on societal structures that seek to confine and limit women. At Gateshead, Jane is subjected to the cruelty of her relatives, treated as an unwanted outsider because of her orphan status. At Lowood, she faces institutional repression under the guise of religious instruction. In both settings, Jane is expected to submit to authority and accept her place in the social hierarchy. However, Jane's inner strength and refusal to be broken by these oppressive forces make her a remarkable heroine.

Throughout her early life, Jane demonstrates a quiet defiance against the forces that seek to control her. Whether enduring the abuse of her cousins or facing the rigid rules of Lowood, Jane holds on to her sense of self-worth and independence. Her defiance is not loud or confrontational, but it is persistent. Even in her darkest moments, Jane refuses to accept the limitations placed on her by society. This resilience is what sets Jane apart and makes her a symbol of feminist strength, even in her youth.

As Jane matures and completes her education, her desire for independence grows. After years as a student and later a teacher at Lowood, she begins to realize that while the school has given her knowledge and stability, it has also become another form of confinement. Jane dreams of a life beyond Lowood, one where she can assert her independence and find fulfillment on her own terms. This longing for autonomy leads her to seek employment as a governess, a role that, while still limited by societal expectations, offers her the opportunity to leave Lowood and begin a new chapter in her life.

Brontë's depiction of Jane's early life at Gateshead and Lowood is not merely a story of suffering and endurance—it is a narrative of resistance and self-discovery. Jane's refusal to be broken by the forces that seek to oppress her lays the foundation for the woman she will become. Her journey is one of survival, but it is also one of empowerment. By the time Jane leaves Lowood, she is no longer the frightened, oppressed child locked in the red room; she is a young woman determined to live life on her terms.

In Jane Eyre, Brontë presents a heroine who refuses to be defined by the limitations imposed on

her by society. From her earliest days at Gateshead, where she faced emotional abuse and neglect, to her years at Lowood, where she endured physical hardship and loss, Jane's spirit of independence never wavers. Her resilience, intellect, and sense of self-worth allow her to navigate the oppressive structures of Victorian society and emerge with a firm sense of who she is. These early years of struggle and quiet rebellion are crucial in shaping Jane's character and set the stage for her continued quest for independence throughout the novel.

CHAPTER TWO

The Journey to Thornfield – Love and the Negotiation of Power

Upon arriving at Thornfield, Jane Eyre embarks on a new chapter in her life, one where the challenges of autonomy, power, and emotional vulnerability take center stage. At Thornfield, she meets Mr. Rochester, a brooding and enigmatic figure whose presence both intrigues and unsettles her. The dynamic between Jane and Rochester is immediately charged with tension—emotional, intellectual, and, perhaps most importantly, a tension of power. Brontë uses the relationship between these two characters to explore complex themes of love, independence, and control, creating one of the most significant relationships in literary history.

From the outset, Jane's position as a governess places her in a precarious societal position. While not a servant, she is also not a member of the upper class. She occupies a middle ground, dependent on the wealth and authority of her employer, Mr. Rochester, for her livelihood. This inherent imbalance of power might have led Jane into a more submissive role, conforming to societal expectations of women as subservient to men, especially those of higher status. However, Jane, true to her character, refuses to allow herself to be defined by the constraints of her position. She meets Rochester as an equal in intellect and moral fortitude, even if she is economically dependent on him.

As Jane and Rochester's relationship develops, Brontë uses their interactions to highlight Jane's inner strength. Although deeply in love with Rochester, Jane does not allow this love to compromise her sense of self. Her emotional vulnerability is clear—she is a young woman in love with a man who is not only older but also much more worldly. Yet, this vulnerability does not strip Jane of her integrity. When Rochester proposes that she become his mistress after the revelation of his marriage to Bertha Mason, Jane refuses. Her decision to leave Thornfield, despite her profound love for Rochester, is one of the most significant feminist moments in the novel. Jane understands that staying with him under such circumstances would mean sacrificing her autonomy and self-respect. In a world where women were often expected to define themselves

through their relationships with men, Jane’s choice to prioritize her own moral integrity over romantic fulfillment is revolutionary.

Jane's refusal to submit to Rochester's desires is rooted in her deep sense of self-worth. She is aware that to remain with Rochester as his mistress would reduce her to a dependent, living outside the bounds of social respectability. But her decision is not driven by societal judgment alone. More importantly, it is a reflection of her internal compass—Jane knows that her sense of identity and autonomy would be compromised if she entered into such a relationship. Her love for Rochester, though powerful, does not outweigh her need to remain true to herself. This is a radical stance for a woman of her time, and Brontë uses it to challenge traditional gender roles and the idea that women must sacrifice their own desires and independence to secure a man’s affection.

Rochester, for his part, is a complicated figure. Though he loves Jane deeply, his attempts to control and manipulate her reveal his flawed understanding of love. He sees Jane as his equal in spirit and intelligence, but his initial desire to keep her as his mistress, despite his marriage to Bertha, exposes his tendency to view love through the lens of possession and control. In his mind, Jane’s love for him should be enough to make her stay, even if it means compromising her principles. However, Jane's departure forces him to confront his own flaws and recognize that true love cannot be based on dominance. It must be rooted in equality and mutual respect.

The power dynamic between Jane and Rochester shifts after Jane leaves Thornfield. While at Thornfield, Rochester holds both financial and social power over Jane, as well as emotional power due to her love for him. But when Jane walks away, she asserts her independence, reclaiming control over her own life. She leaves with nothing but her integrity intact, choosing the uncertainty of life away from Thornfield over the comfort of staying with Rochester under unjust conditions. This act of leaving transforms Jane from someone who is economically dependent into a figure of moral authority.

Rochester’s eventual downfall—his loss of wealth, and his physical injuries—levels the playing field between them. When Jane returns to him, she does so as an equal, no longer reliant on him for her livelihood, and no longer vulnerable to his power. She has inherited a fortune from her uncle and comes back to Thornfield a financially independent woman, ready to engage in a relationship on her own terms. Rochester, now humbled and reliant on Jane’s care due to his injuries, is no longer in a position of dominance. This shift in their relationship represents Brontë’s vision of true love—one that is not based on power or control, but on equality and mutual respect.

Through Jane’s journey at Thornfield, Brontë challenges traditional gender roles and presents a revolutionary view of love and relationships. Jane’s refusal to compromise her independence for

romantic fulfillment is a radical stance that underscores her strength and integrity. The novel ultimately suggests that true love cannot exist without equality and that personal independence and moral integrity are far more valuable than the security of a dependent relationship. By reclaiming her autonomy and choosing to love on her own terms, Jane becomes a powerful symbol of feminist ideals, showing that a woman's worth is not defined by her relationship to a man, but by her own sense of self.

CHAPTER THREE

Solitude and Self-Discovery: The Road to Independence

After Jane Eyre's departure from Thornfield, she is forced into a state of isolation and poverty, where she experiences the harsh realities of life on her own. However, rather than being defeated by her circumstances, this period of solitude becomes a transformative phase in her life, where she not only endures physical hardship but also embarks on a profound journey of self-discovery. Jane's time in isolation is crucial in solidifying her sense of autonomy and strengthening her resolve to live according to her own principles, free from the constraints of societal expectations.

Fleeing Thornfield after discovering Mr. Rochester's secret—that he is already married to Bertha Mason—Jane's flight is an act of deep moral courage. Her decision to leave behind the man she loves, and the life of comfort and stability that could have been hers, reflects her unyielding commitment to her own moral and personal independence. This marks a significant departure from the typical roles women were expected to play in the 19th century, where their lives were largely shaped by their relationships with men. In rejecting Rochester's offer to live as his mistress, Jane not only refuses to compromise her integrity but also chooses the uncertainty of an unknown future over the security of dependence on a man who cannot offer her an equal partnership.

As Jane finds herself alone in the wilderness, hungry and homeless, she is faced with a stark reality: she has no financial means to support herself and must rely entirely on her resourcefulness and inner strength. Her plight during this period highlights the vulnerability of women in Victorian society, who often lacked the means to survive without the protection of men. Despite this, Jane does not regret her decision to leave Thornfield, as she recognizes that her independence and self-respect are worth more than any material comfort she could have obtained by staying with Rochester.

This period of isolation also allows Jane to contemplate her own identity, separate from the influence of others. For the first time, she is free from the constraints of social hierarchy and the

expectations of others. During this time, Jane's reflections on her life and her future grow deeper, and she comes to understand that true independence is not just about escaping control but also about realizing her own desires and ambitions. Jane's isolation is not simply physical but also emotional, giving her the space to think and grow on her own terms.

Her time in isolation eventually leads her to the home of the Rivers family, where she is taken in and nursed back to health. The Rivers siblings—Diana, Mary, and St. John—introduce a new phase of Jane's journey, one that tests her convictions about love, duty, and independence. St. John Rivers, in particular, plays a pivotal role in challenging Jane's sense of self and her beliefs about what kind of life she should lead. St. John, a devout and ambitious clergyman, recognizes Jane's intelligence and capability, but his vision for her life is one that would suppress her individuality and autonomy.

St. John proposes that Jane marry him and accompany him to India as a missionary. He sees this as her duty, and though he claims it is a noble cause, Jane recognizes that accepting such a life would mean sacrificing her identity and desires. St. John's proposal is not one of love but of duty, and he makes it clear that his primary interest is in her usefulness as a missionary, not in her as a person. This offer is in stark contrast to Jane's relationship with Rochester, which, despite its flaws, was based on passion and emotional connection. St. John's proposal, on the other hand, is devoid of warmth and affection, reducing Jane to a mere tool for his ambitions.

Jane's rejection of St. John's proposal is a critical moment in her journey toward autonomy. It is not just a refusal of marriage; it is a rejection of a life of submission and the denial of her own desires. Although St. John offers her the chance to serve a higher purpose through missionary work, Jane understands that true fulfillment for her lies in living a life of her own choosing, rather than conforming to the expectations of others—whether those expectations come from society or from St. John's sense of religious duty. Jane's decision to refuse him demonstrates her commitment to remaining true to herself, even in the face of pressure to sacrifice her individuality for the sake of duty.

Brontë uses Jane's interactions with St. John to further explore the limitations placed on women in Victorian society. St. John, though well-intentioned, represents the patriarchal figure who expects women to suppress their own desires for the sake of duty or social good. Jane, however, rejects this notion, refusing to become a passive object in another man's life, no matter how righteous the cause is. Her rejection of St. John's proposal is not just about rejecting an unloving marriage but about affirming her right to live life on her own terms.

Throughout this period of isolation and self-discovery, Jane grows in her understanding of what it means to be truly independent. Her journey is not just about escaping oppressive forces but about

realizing her own strength and autonomy. By the time Jane leaves the Rivers family to return to Thornfield, she has not only gained a deeper understanding of herself but also reclaimed control over her own destiny. She returns to Thornfield not out of a need for security or love but because she is now in a position to engage in a relationship on her own terms—where she can meet Rochester as an equal.

In this chapter of Jane's life, Brontë critiques the societal expectations that demand women sacrifice their desires for the sake of duty, religion, or social propriety. Jane's rejection of St. John's offer of marriage is a powerful assertion of her independence, showing that true autonomy comes from living authentically and not conforming to the roles imposed by others. It is through this period of isolation that Jane achieves the self-discovery and inner strength necessary to shape her own future, setting the stage for her return to Thornfield as a woman who is fully in control of her own life.

CHAPTER FOUR

Empowered Reunion: Jane's Path to Independence

After her period of isolation and self-discovery, Jane Eyre returns to Thornfield with a newfound sense of autonomy, strength, and emotional clarity. Jane who left Thornfield in turmoil and despair is not the same person who comes back. She has experienced a profound transformation, gaining both financial independence and a deeper understanding of herself. This final chapter of Jane's journey brings the novel's feminist themes into sharp focus, as she returns to engage in a relationship with Mr. Rochester on her own terms—no longer as a dependent, but as his equal.

When Jane arrives at Thornfield, she finds the once-grand estate reduced to ruins. The physical destruction of Thornfield mirrors the emotional and moral collapse that occurred after Jane's departure. Mr. Rochester, the once-powerful figure who held sway over Jane's life, has been humbled by the fire that destroyed his home and left him blind and physically weakened. Rochester's fall from power is significant, as it levels the playing field between him and Jane. No longer is she the young governess, financially dependent on her employer. Now, Jane is a woman with her own wealth, her own autonomy, and a clear sense of her moral and personal boundaries.

Rochester's physical blindness is also symbolic. Previously, he was blind to the true nature of love, confusing control and dominance for affection. But now, having lost both his sight and his former power, he can no longer view Jane as an object to be controlled. Instead, he is forced to recognize her as an independent woman, equal in spirit and now in status. This shift in their dynamic allows for a more balanced relationship, one founded on mutual respect rather than control.

Jane's return to Rochester is not driven by pity or a desire to care for him out of duty. It is important to note that she does not come back to him because he is weak and in need of help, but because she chooses to. She returns with the full agency of a woman who knows what she wants and understands that she deserves to be treated as an equal. Her decision to re-engage with Rochester is not a compromise or a sacrifice of her independence. It is the culmination of her journey towards self-realization. She returns to him on her terms, with her wealth, and with the freedom to walk away if she chooses.

Their reunion is marked by a shift in the power dynamic. Rochester, who once held emotional and financial power over Jane, now relies on her in a way that equalizes their relationship. He no longer tries to dominate her or manipulate her emotions. Instead, he is humbled and contrite, acknowledging the mistakes he made in trying to control her earlier. For the first time, their relationship is based on mutual understanding, respect, and love that transcends the societal roles that once constrained them.

Brontë uses this final phase of Jane's journey to challenge traditional gender roles and offer a feminist reimagining of love and marriage. In the 19th century, marriage was often an institution in which women were expected to be submissive and dependent on their husbands. Women had few legal rights and were often seen as property, expected to serve their husbands and raise children. Jane's journey, however, defies these expectations. She refuses to enter into a marriage where she would be subservient or morally compromised. Her eventual union with Rochester is on her terms, and it represents a significant departure from the patriarchal norms of the time.

What makes Jane's return to Rochester so radical is that it is a choice made from a position of strength, not weakness. She does not return because she needs a man to support her or give her status. She comes back because she loves Rochester, and she knows that, finally, they can be together as equals. Brontë suggests through this reunion that true love is not about power or control, but about mutual respect and partnership. Jane's story, from her time as a vulnerable orphan to a woman with her own wealth and independence, is a powerful testament to the idea that women can—and should—claim their own destinies, free from the constraints of societal expectations.

This feminist conclusion is underscored by Jane's financial independence, which plays a crucial role in her ability to return to Rochester on her own terms. The inheritance she receives from her uncle gives her the freedom to make choices that are not dictated by her economic circumstances. In the world of Victorian England, where women's financial dependence on men often dictated their fates, Jane's newfound wealth is a symbol of her hard-won autonomy. She no longer has to rely on a man for her survival, and this allows her to engage in a relationship that is based on

love, not necessity.

Jane’s return to Rochester, then, is not a traditional romantic resolution but a feminist one. It is the culmination of a journey in which she has fought for her independence, asserted her moral integrity, and refused to be controlled by the expectations of others. Her reunion with Rochester is a reward for her strength and resilience, not a submission to societal norms. By returning to him as his equal, Jane redefines what it means to love and be loved in a world that seeks to diminish women’s autonomy.

In the end, Jane’s story is not about finding fulfillment in a man but about finding fulfillment in herself. Her love for Rochester is part of her journey, but it is not the defining aspect of her character. What defines Jane is her unwavering sense of self, her moral courage, and her determination to live life on her own terms. Brontë’s novel, through the lens of Jane’s return to Thornfield, offers a revolutionary vision of love, marriage, and womanhood, one that champions equality and independence as the foundation for a truly fulfilling life.

CONCLUSION

In conclusion, Jane Eyre stands as a timeless exploration of a woman's struggle for autonomy, equality, and the pursuit of her own convictions. Charlotte Brontë crafted a heroine who, despite facing immense challenges—loneliness, cruelty, and moral dilemmas—refuses to sacrifice her self-respect or independence. As John Pfordresher highlights in The Secret History of Jane Eyre, Brontë's personal experiences of emotional turmoil, forbidden love, and family crises deeply influenced the novel, infusing it with layers of rebellion and resilience that continue to captivate readers.

Jane Eyre is more than just a Gothic romance; it is a powerful feminist statement, offering readers insight into the inner strength and moral courage required to defy societal expectations. Jane's journey from oppression to self-realization is a narrative that resonates with readers to this day, making it essential to experience the novel firsthand. Reading the original allows one to fully appreciate Brontë's complex characters and rich narrative.

BIBLIOGRAPHY

Brontë, Charlotte. Jane Eyre. Penguin Classics, edited with an introduction and notes by Stevie Davis, Penguin Books, 2006.

Brontë, Emily. Wuthering Heights. Penguin Classics, edited with an introduction by Pauline Nestor, Penguin Books, 2003.

Brontë, Anne. The Tenant of Wildfell Hall. Oxford University Press, 2008.

Chopin, Kate. The Awakening. Dover Thrift Editions, Dover Publications, 1993.

Eliot, George. Middlemarch. Oxford World's Classics, Oxford University Press, 2008.

Brontë, Charlotte. Villette. Penguin Classics, edited with an introduction by Helen Cooper, Penguin Books, 2004.

Pfordresher, John. The Secret History of Jane Eyre: How Charlotte Brontë Wrote Her Masterpiece. W.W. Norton & Company, 2017.